According to China scholar David Chambers, the role of intelligence was actually crucial in preserving the CCP from extinction through the difficult years of the 1920s and early 1930s. Reliable intelligence enabled the Communists to stage the successful breakout from Jiangxi that began the Long March in 1934 as well as to penetrate the KMT's political and military establishment, which made the eventual seizure of power possible.[46] A close eye was also kept on dissident voices within the Party, which led to a climate of fear within their own ranks.

Before the 1949 communist takeover, the CCP had two intelligence agencies, Shehui Bu (the Social Bureau) and the Qingbao Bu (the Intelligence Bureau). This complex intelligence and security apparatus was headed by the notorious Kang Sheng between 1939 and 1946. He was, however, relieved of his command and stripped of other key posts when Mao and the top party leadership realized how much damage he had done to the Party with a 'Rectification Movement' in the early 1940s. Kang's campaign became especially vicious in 1943, when he detained over a thousand alleged 'spies' and 'enemy agents'. Among them were well-known intellectuals who had helped build the Party. Between 40,000 and 80,000 Party members were expelled and many of those went insane, while others committed suicide, either by hanging or drowning themselves in rivers or wells.[47]

But even with his ouster as intelligence chief, Kang remained a trusted member of Mao's inner circle and remained a close confidante of the Chairman after the Communist takeover. In November 1949, China's new rulers established the Ministry of Public Security, a new entity that was supposed to take over the internal counterespionage and security duties of the Shehui Bu, which would then be abolished. But, in practice, the Shehui Bu remained operational inside China until 1953, possibly until as late as 1954.

The system turned out to be too unwieldy. So, in 1955, the Investigation Department of the Chinese Communist Party (ID/CCP) was established as the principal civilian intelligence agency with the Second Department, the General Staff Department of the PLA in charge of military intelligence duties. Reigning over all this was a body called the Central Intelligence Committee, about which very little is known.[48]